Cognitive and Neurobiological Approaches to Plasticity (CNAP) Phase 2 COBRE Center
Guidelines and Procedures for Primary Project Leaders
Grant Submission, Graduation, and Program Removal Guidelines

Last Updated: 7-6-2022

The purpose of this document is to outline the guidelines and procedures relating to Project Leader (PL) standing and progression in the CNAP Phase 2 COBRE program. The content of this document has been taken primarily from the COBRE program announcement PAR-19-312 and the Administrative Core Section of the CNAP COBRE Phase 2 grant application, submitted in September 2021. The guidelines in this document supersede any guidelines outlined in previous CNAP or NIGMS documents.

COBRE Project Program Milestones and Metrics of Success

Milestones. The major program milestones for PLs are:

(1) development of a functional laboratory (including installation of new equipment) and recruitment of students and staff

(2) progress toward completion of experiments to address specific aims of the primary project

(3) submission of abstracts and delivery of presentations at national and international meetings based on the primary project (typically, 1-2 per year of support)

(4) submission and publication of high-impact articles in quality peer-reviewed journal based on the primary project (typically, 1 publication per year of support)

(5) collection of preliminary data suitable for a Research Project Grant (RPG) application

(6) submission of an RPG application within two years of support

(7) development of national reputation in research area

(8) funding of an RPG and program graduation

PLs should achieve milestones 1-6 within two years of support and make significant progress toward achieving milestone 7-8. Performance in the program will be gauged based on the achievement of program milestones.

Metrics of Success. The goal of the program is to promote the PL's ability to secure extramural funding in the form of an RPG. The metrics of success will measure progress toward and achievement of the milestones including:

(1) regular reporting on achievement of COBRE project aims

(2) regular reporting on the collection of preliminary data for an RPG submission

(3) service on study sections, journal reviewing and/or editorial board service, professional society governance boards, and other indicators of esteem in discipline

(4) the number of national/international conference presentations based on the primary project

(5) the number and quality (e.g., impact factor) of peer-reviewed publications based on the primary project

(6) the number of submissions of RPGs

(7) percentile ranks of RPGs

The metrics of success are collected through the evaluation processes described in the Assessment of Progress section.

Assessment of Progress

Progress of PLs toward graduation will be assessed through two mechanisms. PLs will provide progress reporting through the evaluation system (i.e., Piestar) prior to the two semi-annual External Advisory Committee (EAC) meetings. The reporting includes descriptions of accomplishments, plans, and changes as a part of the "semi-annual progress" module. Additional reporting on graduation plans and progress will occur through the "graduation progress" module, which will articulate planned criteria for graduation. The PD, AD, project mentors, and EAC member(s) will review the plan in the graduation progress module and provide feedback on the proposed criteria for graduation on a case-by-case basis. PLs are also encouraged to contribute to the assessment of center function by responding to questionnaires. Semi-annual and graduation progress reports are due in advance of the winter videoconferencing meetings and the summer site visit with the EAC. PLs should consult the guidelines and specific deadlines within the evaluation system for further details of reporting requirements.

The second reporting mechanism is the completion of the Research Performance Project Report (RPPR) and Scientific Information Reporting System (SIRS) reports to the National Institute of General Medical Sciences (NIGMS). The RPPR and SIRS reports are due annually 60 days prior to the end of the grant budget period. Internal deadlines for completion will typically be 3-4 weeks prior to the NIGMS deadline. PLs should consult the guidelines and specific deadlines within the evaluation system for further details of reporting requirements.

PLs may also be required to provide additional progress reporting in the event of poor performance or the failure to submit an investigator-initiated RPG as lead PI within two years of support (see "Probationary Procedures").

In addition to the descriptive reporting on progress for metrics 1-3, PLs should supply detailed information for assessing metrics 4-7. Any conference submissions/presentations or manuscript submissions/publications that used COBRE project funds or CNAP research cores should be reported in the evaluation system using the "Publications and Presentations" module. In addition, CNAP grant support should be acknowledged within the presentation or publication: "This project was supported by a grant from the National Institute of General Medical Science GM113109 of the National Institutes of Health. The content is solely the responsibility of the authors and does not necessarily represent the official views of the National Institutes of Health." Any grant applications or funded grants that stem directly from the COBRE project and/or rely on CNAP research cores should also be reported in the evaluation system using the "Proposals" module.

Grant Submission Requirements

PLs must submit an investigator-initiated RPG application on which they are the lead PI by the end of two years of COBRE support to be eligible to receive continued funding through the COBRE award. RPG grants include most NIH R-grants (e.g., R03, R15, R21, R01) and comparable grants at any extramural funding agency. Grant submissions that stem directly from the COBRE award are strongly encouraged, but the grant submission may be in an area of research that does not overlap with the COBRE award. Note that the deadline for grant submission is relative to the start date of the project and must be within two years of that start

date. If a PL fails to meet the grant submission deadline, then they will be removed from the program.

Program Removal

During each semi-annual evaluation, if an individual PL fails to meet relevant program benchmarks, then the EAC will conduct a review (see EAC Review Procedures) to determine whether the PL should be removed from the program. PLs will be removed if they fail to submit an investigator-initiated RPG application as lead PI by the end of two years of COBRE support. Program removal may also occur if review by the EAC indicates a failure by the investigator to make significant progress toward achieving the program milestones. Documented extenuating circumstances such as unexpected problems in project execution (i.e., the need to change the project aims) may result in an adjustment of the timeline for meeting benchmarks. In these cases, the PL may be placed on probation until the goals of the probationary period are met (See “Probationary Procedures”). If a project fails to achieve benchmarks and is deemed unlikely to alter course, then the PL will be removed from the program. EAC approval is required for program removal decisions and the PD must communicate the EAC recommendation to the NIGMS for programmatic and administrative review and approval.

Probationary Procedures

PLs may be placed on probation in the event of poor performance. If the PL is selected for probation, they should develop a set of clear goals and timelines for returning to good standing. During the probationary period, the PL should provide frequent (e.g., weekly or bi-weekly) reports to their mentors, PD, and/or AD on their progress. If the goal(s) of the probationary period are met, then the PL may be returned to normal monitoring status. If the goal(s) are not met, then the PL will be removed from the program (See “Program Removal”).

Graduation

PLs should develop a graduation plan that includes goals for program completion using the graduation progress module in the evaluation system (See “Assessment of Progress”). Graduation plans should consider the timeline for completing program benchmarks and for achieving independent funding status.

There are two main pathways to graduation. One route is through completion of the CNAP COBRE program objectives. Through this route, PLs should be considered for a status change if independence is indicated by the acquisition of sufficient skills and knowledge. Progress towards completion of program Milestones 1-7 will be used to gauge independent status in these instances. The second route is through achievement of independent funding status wherein PLs receive an investigator-driven RPG of any type on which they are the lead PI (i.e., achievement of Milestone 8).

Completion of Program Objectives. PLs may receive up to 3 years of support from the COBRE program, depending on availability of funding. During the final year of support, all PLs will be put forward for consideration to graduate from the program based on progress towards completion of program Milestones 1-7 (See “EAC Review Procedures”). Graduation will occur at the end of the grant year in which the evaluation is performed (i.e., May 31).

PLs will complete the program at the end of their project period. It is possible for a PL project to end without graduation if there is insufficient progress toward meeting program milestones. Extensions beyond the scheduled project end date will not be allowed.

Achievement of Independent Funding Status. Graduation to independent funding status may occur at any time during or after the project period.

The award of any type (e.g., new or renewal) of RPG (e.g., R03, R15, R21, R01 or other investigator-initiated grant of any type) to a PL should be viewed as a milestone and a criterion for changing the status of the PL to independent investigator. The receipt of any award during the project funding period will automatically result in initiation of a graduation evaluation by the EAC (See "EAC Review Procedures").

COBRE support cannot be provided in instances where a PL's new/renewal award is significantly similar to that described in the COBRE program. In these cases, individuals will be graduated from the program following the receipt of a Notice of Award.

Receipt of a R01 or equivalent award will result in graduation, but individuals receiving smaller awards (e.g., R03, R21) may be eligible to continue in the program if the specific aims of the funded RPG are significantly different from the COBRE project. Such cases will be evaluated by the EAC (See "EAC Review Procedures") to determine if graduation or continuation is appropriate. If PLs are selected for graduation, then they may be given funding during a brief transitional period to complete ongoing experimentation. If the PL continues in the COBRE program while co-managing a separate RPG, continued support for personnel (e.g., postdoctoral associates, graduate students, technicians, etc.) associated with the COBRE project but also listed on the other award can be provided. However, the percent efforts of these individuals must be appropriately adjusted. Any proposed change in COBRE project aims and/or PL effort requires prior approval by the PD and NIGMS.

COBRE investigators may not receive simultaneous research project support from an INBRE or other COBRE award.

Privileges for COBRE Graduates

The goal of the COBRE program is to promote the development of an independent and sustainable center. PLs who have acquired independent status through completion of program objectives or by obtaining RPG funding will have the same access to core facilities under the same conditions as active COBRE investigators. Former COBRE members are encouraged to participate in collaborative research efforts by serving as a collaborator or advisor on primary projects or pilot grants. If appropriate, an investigator who has graduated from the program may direct a COBRE core facility and/or serve as a mentor. CNAP graduates will be encouraged to continue their participation in CNAP events such as brown bags, colloquia, and training events (e.g., grant writing, statistical workshops). Post-graduation mentoring will also be available on an informal (unpaid) basis through involvement of the mentors as needed. Individuals who are removed from the program due to poor performance will not be considered as graduates, but they will be encouraged to participate in select CNAP programs and to seek out continued informal mentoring.

EAC Review Procedures

In addition to assessing progress during the semi-annual EAC meetings, the EAC will provide recommendations on graduation and program removal. If an event occurs that requires a review above and beyond the semi-annual meetings, the PD will initiate an EAC review. First, the PD will write to the PL with an outline of considerations that will be addressed during the EAC review. The PL will be invited to supply any relevant written evidence that may inform their case such as updated progress reports or other metrics of success, evidence of extenuating circumstances, or other pertinent evidence that may inform the EAC judgment. In the case of graduation assessments, the EAC will consider the graduation plans outlined in the most recent "graduation progress" report. This will be submitted to the PD and forwarded to the EAC for use in the review process. The EAC will be contacted by the PD over email to initiate the review. PLs will be provided with a copy of the email from the PD to the EAC that outlines their case and any attached supporting documents. The EAC review may take place over email or through a meeting (e.g., videoconference). The project mentors, relevant IAC members, and AD will be included on the initial email and consulted as needed during the review process. The NIGMS program officer may also be consulted on an as-needed basis. EAC recommendations will be summarized in a letter from the EAC chair to the PD that will be forwarded to the candidate and the NIGMS. Program removal decisions must undergo NIGMS programmatic and administrative review and approval prior to any action by the PD. All other decisions will be considered final once the NIGMS program officer has been informed.